Strategy 5: Hindu–Muslim Fault Lines and the Assam Model

The BJP's Assam model of ethno-religious mobilisation forms the fifth pillar of its growth. It is predicated on a sense of Hindus being in danger, a narrative of demographic change driven by the immigrant as 'Muslim' and the BJP's projection of itself as the protector of Hindu identity. An emergent communal divide powered the BJP's rise to ruling-party status in the state. This template also drove its growth in neighbouring West Bengal. We could call it the Assam/Bengal model. A large influx of migrants after the 1971 war with Pakistan and the Assam movement of the 1970s led to the state's politics being split along the 'insider–outsider' narrative. The BJP's demand for the deportation of all 'illegal migrants to Bangladesh'—which preceded the Supreme Court-mandated NRC in 2019—is at least as old as 2006.[144] That is why Himanta Biswa Sarma termed the 2019 general election in Assam as the 'final battle of Saraighat'.[145] It was a reference to the famous 1671 victory of the Ahom king, Raja Chakradhwaj Singha, and his general Lachit Borphukan, over the invading Mughal forces in a battle on the banks of the river Brahmaputra. That battle ended Mughal attempts to conquer Assam. This Saraighat narrative of beleaguered Hindus fighting a back-against-the-wall war against invading Mughal armies also formed the subtext of its 2016 assembly election victory, which resulted in Assam's first BJP government.

Rajat Sethi and Shubrashtha have argued in their history of that campaign that 'calling the elections "The Last Battle of Saraighat" against the demographic, cultural and political aggression of the illegal Bangladeshis threatening the essence of the state made this a people's movement'.[146] As mentioned before, Assam has the highest proportion of Muslims of any large state in India, after Jammu and Kashmir: 34 per cent. West Bengal has more Muslims—24.6 million—but they make up a slightly lower proportion of the population at 27.01 per cent.[147] It is no accident that the two states became home to an ethno-religious mobilisation based on notions of Hindu identity, starting with areas where Muslims were demographically dominant or large enough to be the primary factor in elections.